

User Testing and Revision

Watch someone else use it, then prove your fix worked



The Week 10 question

Your interaction worked in Week 7. Your accessibility audit passed in Week 8. So why does a real person still get stuck?

This week trades your own judgement for observed evidence: watch a real person try to use what you built, then justify a change with what you actually saw.

From self-review to observed evidence

The self-review problem

Weeks 1-9 built structure, hierarchy, layout, colour, response, interaction and access on your own judgement. That judgement cannot see this week's failures.

Why it happens

You already know where every link goes and what every label means. That knowledge makes you the worst possible judge of whether a stranger can find them.

Learning outcomes

Run a lightweight usability test.

Record what actually blocks a participant, in their words and actions, not your interpretation of their competence.

Distinguish a blocker from a preference, and triage findings by severity.

Write a revision justified by a specific observed moment, then retest to confirm it worked.

The five-second test

Show the page for five seconds, then hide it and ask what the participant remembers and what they think the page is for.

Reveals whether the top of the page communicates its purpose at all, before a participant reads a single word of body text.

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The first-click test

Give one task, watch only the first click. If the first click is wrong, everything after it is a recovery from a bad start, not a real reading of the design.

Best suited to navigation and information-architecture questions: does the label a participant expects actually exist, in the place they expect it?

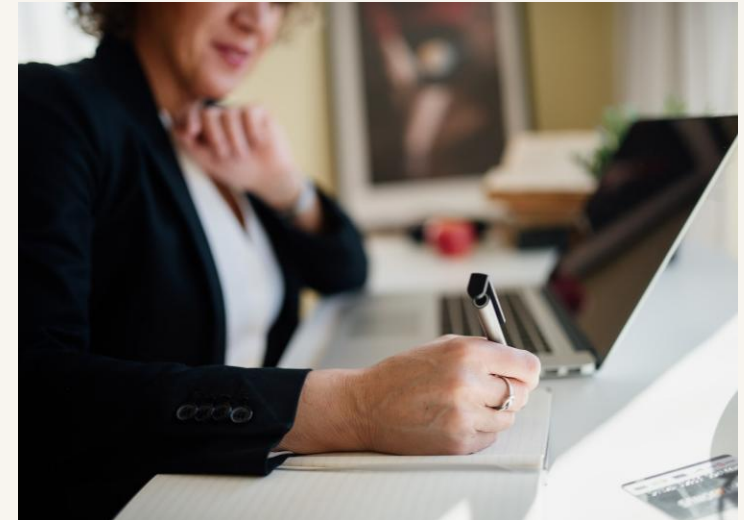
The think-aloud protocol

Think-aloud protocol

Ask the participant to speak their thoughts continuously while attempting a task: what they see, what they expect, what confuses them, before they act.

Choosing a method for what you have

Five-second suits a landing page's clarity. First-click suits navigation. Think-aloud suits a full task flow with forms or multiple steps.



Writing a task scenario: a bad example

```
<p>  
Click the "Subscribe" button in the  
top navigation bar to sign up for  
our newsletter.  
</p>
```

Read this as a task scenario: does it state a goal, or does it name a click path?

Why it fails, and a better version

Why that scenario fails

It names the exact button and its exact location. The participant is now testing whether they can follow directions, not whether they can find the feature on their own.

A better version

“You want to be told by email whenever this site publishes something new. Show me how you would do that.” States a goal in the participant's own words and lets the interface prove or fail to prove itself.

What the better scenario tests

A goal-based scenario lets any hesitation, wrong click, or giving up stand as real evidence, not a scripted result.

If the participant succeeds without help, the interface itself communicated the path. If they don't, that failure belongs to the design, not to unclear instructions.

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Recruiting a participant

A classmate who has not seen your site is enough for this course. Recruit someone unfamiliar with your specific design decisions, not someone who already knows your intentions.

Someone who has watched you build it, or discussed the brief with you, will fill gaps with knowledge a real visitor won't have.

The moderator's role

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Stay quiet during the task. Do not explain, hint, or rescue. Note the moment you feel the urge to help; that urge marks exactly where the design failed.

Common moderator mistakes

Leading questions (“you'd click here, right?”), explaining before the participant tries, and treating a hard task as a test of the participant instead of the design.

An observation template

Columns: step, participant action, direct quote, elapsed time, blocker severity.

Fill it in live during the session, not from memory afterwards — memory smooths over exactly the hesitations and wrong turns that are the evidence you need.

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Worked observation example



Step + action

What the participant did, in their own path through the interface.



Direct quote

Their exact words, not a paraphrase.



Elapsed time

How long the step took, from task start.



Blocker severity

Blocker, friction, or polish — assigned live.

Blocker vs. preference

A blocker stops the task or forces the participant to give up and restart. A preference is a completed task with a complaint. Fix blockers first; preferences are a lower-priority backlog.

Reading hesitation as data: a long pause, re-reading a label twice, or scrolling back up are signs the interface failed to confirm the participant's guess quickly enough, even when the task eventually succeeds.

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Severity triage: three levels



Blocker

Task fails, or the participant gives up and restarts.



Friction

Task succeeds with a visible struggle or wrong turn.



Polish

Task succeeds smoothly; only a stated preference remains.

Triage worked example

A confusing label that costs 5 extra seconds is friction, not a blocker.

A submit button with no visible focus state that a keyboard user cannot find at all is a blocker, even if a mouse user never notices it — severity depends on whether the task fails, not on how many participants hit it.

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From observation to root cause: five whys

Problem: participant missed the contact link. **Why?** It was in the footer. **Why is that a problem?** They expected primary navigation to hold it. **Why?** The nav pattern on similar sites places contact there. **Why does that matter?** Convention sets expectation before your labelling does.

Stop once the answer names a design decision you can actually change.

Writing a revision justification

Cite the specific observed moment (quote, timestamp, task), name the exact change, and state the predicted effect.

A justification without an observed moment is a guess wearing a research citation — examiners and real teams both discount it the same way.

Two worked case studies

Case study 1: navigation failure

Observed: participant scanned top nav twice, said “I don't see contact anywhere,” then opened the hamburger menu after 40s. Revision: add a persistent Contact link to the top nav, not just the footer.

Case study 2: form error clarity

Observed: participant submitted an empty required field, said “did that work?”, clicked submit twice more. Revision: inline error text plus colour, with focus moved to the invalid field.



What counts as evidence after one test

What NOT to change

One participant's dislike of a font size or a colour they find “boring” is a preference, not a pattern. A single opinion should not override a decision made with evidence in Weeks 3-6.

When $n=1$ is still trustworthy

A hard blocker — task fails, participant gives up, or a keyboard/screen-reader path is impossible — is trustworthy from a single test, because the interface objectively failed regardless of who tried it.



Retesting after a revision

Retesting after a revision

Run the same task again, ideally with a different participant, after making the change. Confirm the specific blocker is gone, not just that something looks different.

When a revision fails on retest

If the retest participant still misses the fixed element, the diagnosis was wrong, not just the first attempt at a fix. Go back to the five-whys step rather than patching the same visual change again.

Ethics and common pitfalls

Documenting a session ethically

Ask consent before recording notes or screens. Record what the participant did and said, not judgements about their competence. “Did not find the link in 40 seconds” is data; “user was confused” is an opinion.

Common pitfalls

Testing your own site, testing too late to act on findings, and recruiting an overly helpful participant who explains your interface back to you instead of struggling with it honestly.

Bridging to Assignment 3 and 4

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Assignment 3 asks for a completed keyboard test and a 300-word account of two revisions. Assignment 4's process dossier needs testing evidence and a change log.

Writing the testing-evidence section

State the method, the task scenario, one direct observed quote or moment, the specific revision, and the predicted or confirmed effect. Four short paragraphs beat a page of general impressions.



Studio task

Run one 5-minute think-aloud test on a partner's site from an earlier week.

Fill in the observation template live.

Produce two justified revisions, citing the specific observed moment for each.

Testable review checklist

Task scenario states a goal, not a click path.

Observation template is filled in live with quotes and timing.

Each revision cites a specific moment.

A retest confirms the fix, not just a visual change.

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Further practice and next week

Further practice

Steve Krug's “Rocket Surgery Made Easy” and the Nielsen Norman Group's articles on think-aloud protocols and severity ratings both extend this week's method for future projects.

Next week

Publication and performance: checking assets, metadata, source attribution and loading decisions before the whole site goes live.